

The Body - Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 47:34

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Last talk, we did the whole business of how the mind experiences the body. And we looked especially at those four great elements. But of course there is the body as an organism, and the first thing that always strikes me about this little book called Human Body — whenever I pick it up and read a bit, I'm absolutely gobsmacked. For instance, the brain contains twelve billion neurons and fifty billion supportal glial cells. That's twelve billion neurons. The mind boggles. You can fit all that inside your skull. Twelve billion. It's an amazing figure.

Then it goes on about the spinal cord. There's another one here that's even slightly more interesting in a way. Every second, two million oxygen-bearing red blood cells die. Every second, two million oxygen-bearing red blood cells die. I mean, it's just — I don't, I'm not aware of that, are you? But they are replaced at the same rate by new ones generated in the process of erythropoiesis, something like that. This begins in the kidney cells, which are stimulated by low oxygen levels to release a hormone. I'm not going to say that again. The hormone travels to the body's red bone marrow, which stimulates increased production, raising the blood oxygen levels. And these cells have to make their way through the bone into the blood. Well, that's remarkable, isn't it?

When you read books like this and you realise all this stuff's going on and you haven't a clue, absolutely haven't a clue, you do feel a bit like a body snatcher, like you're in this body and somehow you're not really connected. So that's our first contemplation, really, that the mind simply doesn't know this stuff. There's nothing in the Buddha's teaching — I mean, if he'd have known, for instance, that malaria was carried by mosquitoes, I think he'd have told us. But he didn't. And you probably know that the word malaria comes from the Italian malaria, bad air, because the Romans thought it was the bad air off the swamp that was giving them the illness. It's only in very recent times, over the past hundred or so, fifty years, that we've got these facts.

What comes across to me is that every one of these little cells produces its own energy and a bit more for us. And it's got its own little intelligence. It knows what it's supposed to do. It's supposed to go and pick up oxygen, deposit and then die. And it's just remarkable, right?

So it's contemplating the fact that we have this connection with the body, which is absolutely intimate. Our identity lies with the body. How do you know that? You know that when serious illness comes along,

when death looms in your face, the fear, the anxiety that comes, even though all this science is telling you, you can't be the body. The body is made up of billions and billions of cells and they're all dying. They're all dying all the time. The cornea in your eye is changed every week. Every week, got a new cornea, got a new eye. Amazing. And supposedly, the body changes all its cells within a period of seven years. So I've had ten bodies. Ten completely renovated bodies. It's amazing. Ten completely re-gear'd bodies. I shall leave you with that.

So now the Buddha knows this, of course. He knows that the body is not him or whatever. And there's a whole discourse which is devoted to the body. It's called the *Kāyagatāsati Sutta*. So *kāya* means body. *Gati* means towards the body or going or about the body. *Sati* means awareness of it. And *sutta* means discourse.

I must put you onto this website. It's absolutely wonderful. It's run by a monk called Ānanda Jyoti, who's an English fellow who was with me in the monastery I was at in Burma. He's ended up being quite a good, a very good scholar. And he lives now in Thailand. What he's done with various discourses is put the translation underneath the Pali so you can actually see how the words all connect. It's really quite interesting for those of you who want to know a bit of Pali.

Anyway, it starts off with the monks being in this hall and they're saying, "Wonderful, friends! Marvellous, friends! How it is said that the gracious one who knows, who sees, the worthy one, the perfect *Sambuddha*, mindfulness related to the body when it has been developed and made much of, yields great fruit and brings great advantages."

And then just then, the Buddha's got up from his seat and he's interrupted them. And he said, "What were you talking about before I came in?" So they tell him that they've been talking about this contemplation of the body. So he takes the opportunity to go into it in greater detail.

The first thing, of course, he goes into is the breath. When you read this, it translates as "he breathes..." So he sits cross-legged, setting his body up straight. He goes to the wilderness, to the root of a tree, to an empty place. That normally means that in the wilderness is the cold season, the root of a tree is in the hot season, and the hut is in the rainy season. That's what it's referring to. So this is the life of those ascetics at the time.

And he sits with his legs cross-legged and all that, establishes his mind in front of him, he breathes in, he breathes out. And while breathing in a long breath, he knows, "I am breathing in a long breath." Now, the Pali, you see, is *dīghaṃ assasāmi*. The words, the verb in Pali is like Italian. It includes the pronoun, right? So *mi* means I, *ti* means you, and so on. You can't really say — it's the same in Italian, you can't say, let me think of a word, *amo*, *ami*, *ama*. So it's I love, you love, and so on and so forth. And the way that you get over it in Italian is by using the pronoun. So you've got to be careful about this "I" business.

So in our noting we just say "rising" and "falling," but you can't actually say that in Pali unless you use the

infinitive. So you have to be a little careful when you read this stuff simply because it seems as though he's noting, but it could also just be a reflection. And then you observe the breath. Remember, noting technique is specific to the Mahāsi Sayadaw, but also I found out was used by a Zen teacher, Maezumi Rōshi, in America. So it's not completely unknown in other traditions.

Now, the word he uses here is *pajānāti*. So that *ñā* to know comes right through to our language as "gn," so it's knowledge, "kn," right? And the *pa* means to really know, and we translate it as insight, to actually really feel, to realise *pajānāti*, to actually experience it, right? And he uses that for knowing there's a short breath and a long breath and so on and so forth.

And then he says, "trains himself." He uses a different word, *sikkhati*, to train himself, "experiencing the whole body. I will breathe in the whole body. I will breathe out and making the bodily process calm. I will breathe in. Making the bodily process calm, I will breathe out." So there's your *samatha* quality, right? And that's the beginning of any of our meditation, is to just try to settle the mind on the breath a little bit. And then when you're settled, you open up, right?

He trains himself. What he doesn't say here, which it says, of course, in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish awareness, he says, and then you train that you get to such a point where the *sati* and the *paññā*, the awareness and the intuitive intelligence are at such a pitch that insight arises. For some reason, that's not included here.

Okay, so that's the breath. And then there's always this little verse at the end of things. "For one who is living heedful," he's translated as heedful here, this is *appamādo*, one of his last two words, we normally translate it as diligent. *Ātāpino*, which means *ātāpi*, which means that's very devoted effort. And *pahitattas sa*, which is resolute, right? So these are the three qualities that he expects us to have: to be diligent with the noting, with the feeling, with the seeing; to put real ardent energy into it. Remember, this is not the energy of trying to gain something. It's just the energy of trying to be aware of what it is, right? So it's just enough energy to keep the attention steady on the object and resolute.

I think I've told one or two of you, I had a meditator who I asked him how he could stay on the breath for so long. And he says, "Well, I do what they do when they're pumping iron." So "rising, falling, just one more. Rising, falling, just one more." And that way he keeps himself resolute on observing the breath.

And then he says "with whatever rushing thoughts that are dependent on the household life." This is normally translated as regrets and planning and all that, but I think I agree with him that he translates it as memories and intentions and other things like that, even Bhikkhu Bodhi. But it depends how you look at the word. And it seems to me that it makes much more sense to call them rushing thoughts, which is what we experience, isn't it? So then thoughts constantly coming. And when it says "dependent on the household life," it means dependent on the sense pleasures. That's what it means by the household life. So it doesn't mean to say that a householder, or in our terms, a lay person, can't also have spiritual aims. It's just that when you see in the scriptures this household life, he's referring to those who are entirely

devoted to sense pleasures.

"And are given up when they're given up. And with the giving up of these, the mind becomes internally stable, settles down, becomes well-pointed and concentrated. And like this does a monk develop mindfulness related to the body." When you're reading the scriptures, "monk," the commentary always says, it's whoever's meditating. It's just — I can't remember what the term is for that, you know, all hands on deck. There's a term for parts to mean the whole. Nobody can remember it. Good, I'm not alone.

So then you've got postures. Then he goes on to postures. You've got your four postures. And again, he says, "The monk while going knows I am going," going and coming, so there's your walking meditation. He knows when he's standing and when he's sitting, he knows when he's lying down. And whatever way his body is disposed, he knows it just that way. So again, it's just this business of being with what you're doing — being what you're doing, actually. And then there's the verse again which we've just read.

And then there's the full awareness. He translates full awareness as *sampajañākāri*. So *kāri* means doing. *Pajañña* means to really experience it. And *sam* means with. So basically, it's doing something really mindfully, doing really mindfully what we're doing, *sampajañākāri*.

And so here he's got a whole list of things. Of course it's related to the monastic, but it's easy to translate it to ordinary daily life. So when looking ahead or looking around, he is one who practices full awareness, right? Now in the dining hall, I often see people picking up their plate mindfully, looking around and then keeping their eye on the food in the distance while their legs slowly take them to the counter. And of course you have to, when you get there, you have to watch yourself. You see, when you see what they take, and when one you're gonna watch these thoughts let them go.

So when he's looking around, right, okay. So when he's bending and stretching, he practices full awareness. When he's bearing his robe, bowl and robes — so when we're clothing, et cetera, he practices full awareness of what he's actually doing. Eating, drinking, chewing and tasting. See, it's there, the accent on the whole process of eating. And then "passing a stool and urine," which is nicely put, he practices full awareness.

Now, often, generally speaking, when it comes to that activity in the lavatory, we try to keep the mind somewhere else, Timbuktu or something. But it's a good practice to actually be with the whole process of evacuation. There's a nice word. We'll keep it Latin. Evacuation, although I do like Anglo-Saxon words for it. I suppose just as a little aside, you do know where the word crap comes from. Well, the 19th century was full of wonderful inventions. And there was an invention of the U-pipe, which filled up with water and stopped the smell of the sewer coming up into the room. And the person who did that was called Mr. Crapper. And he's not only left us with this lovely invention, but with a noun, a verb, an adverb, and an adjective. So he's left us quite a legacy. Poor old Mr. Crapper.

Anyway, that's by the by. So this urine business, for a very long time, maybe, I don't know, probably about

five years actually, because I started in that. Every morning, diligently, I drank a third of my urine, according to the yoga practice. You let a third go, you keep the middle third, and you let the rest go, and then you drink it. And the great teaching is it's okay. It's not — it's actually fine and it has vitamins, it has antibiotics, you've got all sorts of things in that, you see. And I never felt better.

Unfortunately there was this other monk, he was American, and you can read this book called *The Waters of Life*, and it's all about maintaining your urine. And he was drinking all of it, all day. And he was coming out with great big boils out of his skin. And we said to him, "You know, I mean, your skin is the biggest excretory organ we've got, actually, through the skin. It's all coming out through the skin, you see." And he said, "No," he says, "no. I've read this book." I don't know what happened to him. He probably disappeared on a great big sore. Poor man. Well, let's hope somebody told him.

Anyway, that's something that you might consider doing yourselves, right? So the early morning pee, give a quarter away, keep a third away, a third you keep in a glass and then the third, the last third you throw away and see if you can get over your disgust, right? We'll come to that in a minute, of course.

So again, it says "when standing, sitting, in sleeping, in walking, in talking and in maintaining silence." In sleeping is a bit difficult. I think you can either understand that to be from the moment you lie in bed until you fall asleep. But some of you may find that as your concentration grows, you actually wake up in sleep and you know you're asleep and you're just awake in it. And I often talk about this student I had — I haven't seen her for a very long time now — but she did lots of practice on visualizing Chinese deities or Buddhas, I can't remember. But such was her concentration, she told me she went to bed and she'd wake up in sleep and she'd be awake all night. But the body would be completely asleep, the brain would be asleep, everything's asleep. Woke up perfectly refreshed. So that tells you something. So that's not an aim. That's not an aim in order to become fully liberated. I'm just saying that's a consequence.

And in maintaining silence. So he practices full awareness. Full awareness. It's just a way of reinforcing the idea that you're actually attending to what you're doing.

Let's have a look now. The next one is — actually I should have talked about my healthy drink in this particular session because this is about the repulsiveness of the body. So I'll just give you the background story of this. It seems as though he gave a very detailed talk about this. So he talked to the *bhikkhus* in many ways on the subject of impurity. He spoke in praise of what is impure. He spoke in praise of the contemplation of what is impure. And he spoke again and again in praise of the stage of meditation on what is impure. Because you can get to access *jhāna*, I think, with this.

They all died. Some of them much younger than you. So just as they died, so I too will die. The fifth one is about the frailty of life. He gives quite a few examples of frailty of life. Like a dewdrop on a blade of grass that gets shaken off by the wind. Like a line drawn on water. Like a mountain stream that doesn't turn back. Or like a spit that's turned on a fire. Each turn it gets closer to being cooked. So is life, each day gets closer to death.

Then the sixth one is about having no protection. There's no way you can avoid it. There's no medicine that can cure death. No mantra can save you from it. No bodyguard can fight it off. There's nothing you can do about it.

The seventh contemplation is about the shortness of life. So even if you live a hundred years, what is a hundred years? When you think about it in cosmic terms, it's almost nothing at all. People think, oh, we've got plenty of time. But actually, when you look at it, life's very, very short.

And then the eighth one is about how swiftly life passes. That it's going past without a pause. It doesn't wait for anything. Every moment that goes by is a moment you can never get back. You can't store it up. You can't save it for later. Each out-breath could be your last one.

So those are the eight contemplations on death. And as you go through them, you begin to get a sense of, well, the urgency really. The urgency of the spiritual life. If you're going to do something about awakening, you'd better get on with it because you don't know how much time you've got left.

Now, this brings us to something which is very, very important. At the end of each of these contemplations on the body, whether it's the parts of the body, the elements, or the charnel ground, there's always the same ending. The meditator dwells contemplating the body in the body internally. That means in your own body. Or externally, in other bodies. Or both internally and externally.

Or he dwells contemplating arising phenomena in the body. Or he dwells contemplating passing away phenomena in the body. Or he dwells contemplating both arising and passing away phenomena in the body. The mindfulness that there is a body is established to the extent necessary just for knowledge and awareness. And he dwells independent, not clinging to anything in the world.

This is the key point. You're not trying to get rid of the body. You're not trying to hate it or be disgusted by it. You're trying to develop equanimity towards it. Non-attachment. You recognise that this is the body, this is how it works, this is what it's made of, and this is what happens to it. But you don't have to be either attached to it or repulsed by it.

The Buddha's approach is always the middle way. Not indulgence, but not self-mortification either. So even with these contemplations of the unlovely aspects of the body, the point is to come to a balanced understanding. Yes, the body is beautiful in some ways. Yes, it's also made of these rather ordinary elements and will decay. Both are true. And you can hold both truths without being knocked off balance by either one.

This is what we mean by developing wisdom about the body. You see it clearly, as it really is, without the distortions of attachment or aversion. And from that clear seeing comes freedom. Freedom from being driven around by bodily desires and fears.

Recently, you probably won't know this, but there was a very good footballer who was taking the plane

across the channel and unfortunately the plane dropped in the water. I can't remember his name. He drowned. He was only about 26 or so. A great tragedy.

And then there's sharing the body with many. I thought this was rather good because they must have known this is the body is shared by many. Shared by the 80 families of worms. Creatures live in dependence on the outer skin, feeding on the outer skin. Creatures live in dependence on the inner skin, feeding on the inner skin. Dependence on flesh, feeding on the flesh. It goes right the way through all these beings. Born, grown, die, evacuate and make water. And even these little creatures that we know live in our bowels, for instance, help us to digest things. Also are born, grow old, die, evacuate and make water. So there's also this contemplation of the fact that our body is home to a lot of other little creatures, not ours, is it?

Then there's the signless death, you know, like Jesus said, we know not the hour nor the day. We just don't know our destiny. We just don't know. That contemplating.

And then the limitless of the extent, the extent of human life is short. One who lives long lives, a hundred years, more or less, that's all. The life of a human being is short. A wise man holds it in contempt and acts as one whose head is burning. Death will never fail to come. A bit gloomy though, isn't it?

And then to contemplate the shortness of the moment. So this is bringing that momentariness to our minds that in fact I'm one breath away. I'm one half breath away from death. I breathe in and that's the end of it.

I always like to tell this rather sad tale. Unfortunately, I can't help but think of it as humorous. But for the people involved, it was obviously very tragic. But there was a woman I knew who came back who met an old love from her early life. And they fell in love. They were quite elderly. And they determined to marry and live together. And they moved into a beautiful cottage. And one morning, he was just about on the way to get the toast and had a heart attack and died. And I always think, if I had a piece of toast with marmalade on it, and I was holding it here in front of my very nose and I was like that, that is suffering, is it not?

So again, just ending, bringing the talk to an end there, this contemplation of death is very powerful. The Buddha says of all the contemplations, this is the most powerful, contemplation on death.

So, just a lot of stuff really to recall when you contemplate the body, just contemplating that we don't actually experience the body, we don't experience these cells, we don't experience what the liver is doing now. I think you might have to have some sort of extraordinary ability to be able to know that. When we're actually looking at the body, it's all our contemplation, a lot of our contemplation is in the body. It's the breathing, the posture, the full awareness of what we're doing all the time. And then there's that whole business of a relationship to the body.

So we've talked about repulsiveness, but as you know, I suggest that in the morning with the very first

beverage that you have, you take the opportunity to thank the body. And that sort of thankfulness, you know, it forms a relationship to the body. See how wonderful it is, and it makes you want to care for it, not put it in danger, not put it where it's going to fall ill, where you're going to fall over and all that sort of stuff. A sense of gratitude.

And of course, the idea of the posture of full awareness and then the repulsiveness to use that in order to find this equanimity with the body, equanimity. And then finally, this very strong, powerful contemplation of death. It really is if you just bring it up.

And as I say, these exercises, like *mettā*, are done best every day, just for a little while, just as little reminders. And then it sort of gets through to you. It begins to change your attitude. It begins to actually have an effect on you. It's no good doing it once every year, you see. It's the constant effort to do it. Just a little reminder, that's all. It does change you. Just the matter changes you over a period of time. It has to. Because every time you reflect on something, you're developing a certain attitude. And old attitudes that you have, which may be contrary to this, are not being developed. So they atrophy. If you don't use your muscles, they just die away.

So it's the same with these attitudes that we have, which you see as unwholesome. If you just let them come up, feel the desire to act that way and let it go, they're slowly dying. They're burning out. But you have to replace it with something positive.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion. May you, by your contemplation of the body, arrive at that place of perfect peace and happiness sooner rather than later.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.